



BELONGING TO GREECE, the island of Crete is home to about 600,000 people. Five times that number visit Crete annually on vacation, making tourism the island's biggest industry. The Mediterranean climate is perfect

CRETANS

A HIGH REGARD FOR TRADITION

Christian calendar

Almost all Cretans are Greek Orthodox but their religious allegiance is not to the Greek mainland church but to Constantinople. Some Cretans still celebrate saints days according to the Julian calendar, which was dropped by most of Europe in the 16th century in favor of the Gregorian calendar. They are known as "Old Calendrists."



A RELIGIOUS ISLAND

Religion is part of everyday life for Cretans, although it is mainly the older generations who attend Sunday church services. Easter is the the biggest festival, with almost the entire island observing the various fasts and feasts.



MINISTERING TO THE COMMUNITY

The village *papas* or priest with his distinctive flowing robes and stovepipe hat is a familiar figure. As well as presiding over baptisms, weddings, and funerals, priests may sometimes find themselves blessing a flock of sheep, or traveling to a church or monastery in some out-of-the-way location to conduct a service.

ROADSIDE SHRINES

There are thousands of small shrines by the roadside in Crete. Some commemorate traffic accidents, but many are simply dedicated to a particular saint. When people pass by they light a candle and say a short prayer.

